Medicapedia

The Illnesses of Geniuses

30 great figures of music, art, literature and science, and the illnesses that shaped their lives and work



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Beethoven composed his Ninth Symphony without hearing a single note. Chopin wrote his finest works while tuberculosis took his breath away. Frida Kahlo painted lying in bed, with a mirror above her. Illness accompanied many geniuses and sometimes changed for ever what they created.

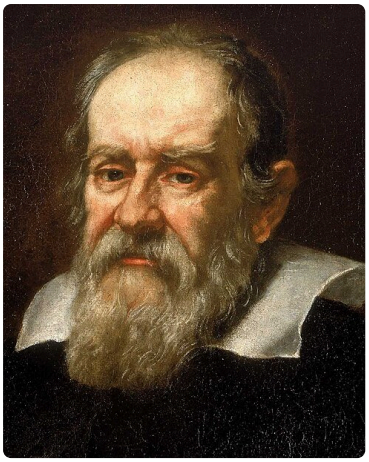
This book gathers 30 of those stories, ordered by each person's date of birth. Each chapter tells what illness they had, how they lived with it, what treatment they received at the time and what medicine says today.

Many diagnoses were made centuries later, from letters, memoirs and documents. When a diagnosis is a hypothesis or disputed, the text says so.

> Medicapedia is a history website. This book does not give medical advice, diagnoses or treatment recommendations.

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01

Galileo Galilei

1564–1642 · Italian astronomer, physicist and mathematician

Illness: Rheumatism and blindness

Galileo Galilei (Pisa, 1564 - Arcetri, 1642) was an Italian astronomer, physicist and mathematician whose observations and experiments changed the way people understood motion and the cosmos. A man of wide interests, he constantly tied theory to practical experiment.

Until 1606 his record shows no serious illness. That year, he and two of his friends fell ill on the same day from an infectious disease. Only Galileo survived, but he was left with rheumatism, a long-term condition causing pain and inflammation in the joints and surrounding tissues, which stayed with him for the rest of his life. Medicine at the time could not identify the exact origin of such an infection and had no effective treatment for rheumatism, so care focused on easing symptoms with traditional remedies and rest.

In his final years, Galileo lost his sight. His medical history records blindness, and his biographers describe a gradual decline that eventually became total. There was no precise diagnosis at the time. Today, historians suggest hypotheses such as glaucoma or cataracts, though specialists do not agree. Some scholars have asked whether long hours of telescope observation or looking directly at the Sun could have played a part, but this link cannot be proven.

Loss of sight did not stop his work. He went on writing and dictating, relying on disciples such as Vincenzo Viviani, who later became one of his first biographers. His life was also shaped by his trial before the Roman Inquisition, which forced him to live under supervision and made it harder to publish his ideas.

Rheumatism and blindness were the physical limits of a man who kept studying until the end. His work on motion and the telescope remains central to the history of science, and his story shows that the decline of his body never fully stopped his inquiry.

Key dates

- **1606** An infection he suffers alongside two friends leaves him with rheumatism for life.
- **1609** He builds his first telescope, an instrument that demands long hours of close observation.
- **1642** He dies in Arcetri, after his final years spent with his sight lost.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/galileo-galilei.html



02

John Milton

1608–1674 · poet, essayist and English civil servant

Illness: Progressive blindness

John Milton (London, 1608 – 1674) was one of the greatest poets in the English language and the author of Paradise Lost. His blindness shaped his final decades, although the sources of his time do not describe precisely how it began or what it involved. Milton gradually lost his sight in middle age, while he continued to work as a civil servant and a writer of political pamphlets. Over time, the loss of vision forced him to rely on other people to write and to read.

During the years of the Commonwealth, Milton worked for the Council of State and wrote in defence of freedom of the press and republican principles. Medicine in his day had no precise diagnosis for disorders of the eye, and the available treatments were largely palliative, with no proven effectiveness. No detailed medical record survives, so it is impossible to know with certainty what happened to him.

Today historians of medicine propose several hypotheses, and there is no consensus. Among the most discussed are glaucoma, a condition in which raised pressure inside the eye damages the optic nerve, and cataracts, in which the lens of the eye becomes clouded. Some scholars suggest a combination of both. These are reasonable hypotheses, but the surviving evidence cannot confirm them.

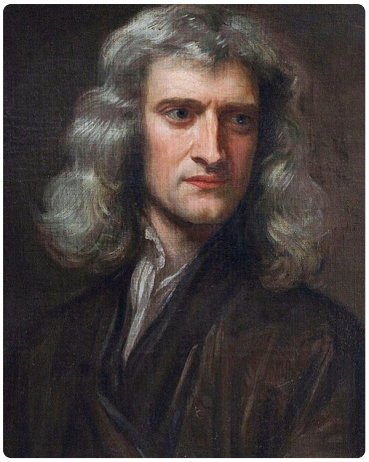
Blindness changed the way Milton worked. He is said to have composed his verses in his mind, mostly at night, and dictated them the next morning to his assistants. This method affected the rhythm and structure of his later works. After the Restoration of 1660 he lost much of his public role and devoted himself almost entirely to writing his major poems. Paradise Lost appeared in 1667 and is regarded as the culmination of his career.

Milton died in 1674 of kidney failure, according to the sources, and his story of blindness has become associated with the image of a poet who kept writing when he could no longer read for himself.

Key dates

- **1625** He enters Christ's College, Cambridge, where he begins his training for the Church of England.
- **1655** He publishes the Defensio Pro Se, a reply to a personal attack, during his active political years.
- **c. 1660** After the Restoration he loses much of his public visibility, at a time when his sight is already severely impaired.
- **1667** Paradise Lost is published, its lines having been dictated to his assistants over the years.
- **1674** He dies in London of kidney failure and is buried in the church of St Giles.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/john-milton.html



03

Isaac Newton

1643–1727 · English physicist and mathematician

Illness: Psychological crisis of 1693 (possible mercury poisoning)

Isaac Newton (1643-1727) was an English physicist and mathematician, author of the Principia, the work in which he formulated the law of universal gravitation and laid the foundations of classical mechanics. Alongside his scientific work, he devoted much of his life to alchemy and theology, and his biography is marked by isolation and constant dedication to study.

The sources describing his health focus on one episode: a severe psychological crisis in 1693. For months he withdrew from social life, ate and slept irregularly, and showed depression and bursts of extreme suspicion. In his correspondence with the philosopher John Locke, he accused him of things he had never done, a trait historians read as part of the crisis rather than as real events. No diagnosis from the period survives. Medicine of the time did not have the concept of depression as we understand it, and there is no reliable record of a specific treatment beyond the care given by those around him. Records linked to his name also list stammering, but there is not enough information to describe it accurately.

The most debated explanation comes from a study published in 1979, which found in his hair a concentration of mercury, a highly neurotoxic substance, about fifteen times the normal level. Because Newton handled mercury in his alchemical experiments, many researchers believe chronic poisoning may have contributed to his condition and to changes in his behaviour. Other historians attribute the crisis to the breakdown of his relationship with his protégé Nicolas Fatio de Duillier. The mercury hypothesis is the most widely accepted, but it cannot be confirmed, since a hair analysis cannot establish the cause with certainty.

The crisis did not end his career. After writing the Principia he moved to London, where he held prestigious posts at the Royal Mint and kept his interests in alchemy and religion. For this reason, the 1693 episode is now seen as an intense period within a highly productive scientific life, rather than as a turning point that ended it.

Key dates

- **1693** He suffers a severe psychological crisis, with isolation, insomnia, depression and episodes of paranoia.
- **1693** His correspondence with John Locke reflects groundless accusations made during the crisis.
- **1727** He dies in London at the age of 84.
- **1979** A study finds mercury in his hair at roughly fifteen times the normal concentration.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/isaac-newton.html



04

Johann Sebastian Bach

1685–1750 · German Baroque composer and organist

Illness: Cataracts and blindness

Johann Sebastian Bach (1685-1750) was a German composer, organist and teacher of the Baroque period, and the most important member of the Bach family of musicians. His vast and varied output is today a central reference in Western music. Yet the last years of his life were marked by failing eyesight that ended in blindness.

The sources do not allow us to establish exactly when his eye problems began. Accounts of the period suggest that his sight declined gradually, to the point that reading scores and copying music, which he had done throughout his career, became difficult. Today the most commonly proposed explanation is a cataract, a clouding of the lens, the natural transparent structure inside the eye. Some specialists have argued that it may instead have been glaucoma, a condition in which raised pressure inside the eye damages the optic nerve. These remain hypotheses, since no detailed clinical descriptions survive.

In the eighteenth century, cataract surgery meant pushing the clouded lens back into the eye, without effective anaesthesia or reliable hygiene, so the risk of infection was very high. Bach was operated on in 1749. According to the most widely repeated account, the operation was unsuccessful, and soon afterwards he underwent a second procedure performed by an itinerant oculist. He seemed to regain some vision at first, but his sight worsened again and he became blind. He died in Leipzig on 28 July 1750, aged 65, after complications that followed the surgery. Today it is considered likely that infection or severe inflammation contributed to his death, although this cannot be confirmed.

Blindness did not stop his work at once. In his final years he revised and extended many earlier compositions, and some, such as The Art of Fugue, were left unfinished. He probably relied more and more on copyists and family members to write out his manuscripts, which changed the way he worked in his last months. His music, however, continued to grow in reputation after his death, and his illness plays only a small part in the image later generations formed of him.

Key dates

- **1749** He undergoes a first cataract operation, which the sources describe as unsatisfactory.
- **1750** A second procedure, carried out by an itinerant oculist, leaves the composer completely blind.
- **1750** He dies in Leipzig on 28 July, aged 65, after complications following the surgery.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/johann-sebastian-bach.html



05

Leonhard Euler

1707–1783 · Swiss mathematician and physicist

Illness: Progressive blindness

Leonhard Euler was a Swiss mathematician and physicist, one of the most prolific authors in the history of science and the creator of much of today's mathematical notation. His eyesight began to fail around the middle of his career, and he eventually lost nearly all of it, although he never stopped working.

The first clear sign came after a near-fatal fever around 1735. In 1738 Euler became almost blind in his right eye. He blamed the strain of the cartographic work he carried out for the St Petersburg Academy, but the real cause of that blindness remains a matter of speculation among historians. While he was in Berlin, the vision in that eye kept worsening, to the point that Frederick the Great referred to him as the Cyclops.

In 1766 a cataract was found in his left eye, the only one he still had good use of. A cataract is a clouding of the lens of the eye that blurs vision. At the time, the usual procedure was couching, which meant pushing the clouded lens out of the line of sight with a needle. The operation briefly improved his sight, but complications left him almost totally blind in that eye too. Retrospective hypotheses about the origin of his problems, such as the fever, the visual strain or a general illness, are still debated without consensus.

His blindness did not slow his output. He compensated with an extraordinary capacity for mental calculation and a remarkable memory. He is said to have memorised Virgil's Aeneid. He dictated much of his work to scribes and to his son, and his writings grew to a very large number of pages. His second wife, Salome Abigail Gsell, whom he married in 1776, accompanied him in his final years. He died in St Petersburg in 1783 after suffering a stroke.

Key dates

- **1735** A near-fatal fever comes before the vision problems that appeared a few years later.
- **1738** He becomes almost blind in his right eye.
- **1766** A cataract is found in his left eye, which eventually leaves him almost totally blind.
- **1783** He dies in St Petersburg, almost blind, without having stopped working.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/leonhard-euler.html



06

Francisco Goya

1746–1828 · Spanish painter and printmaker

Illness: Progressive deafness

Francisco de Goya (Fuendetodos, 1746 – Bordeaux, 1828) was one of Spain's greatest painters and printmakers, and one of the most influential figures in Western art. His work moved through Rococo and Neoclassicism toward a more personal, realistic and morally charged style.

Goya's deafness did not come on suddenly, but it had a decisive moment. In 1793 he suffered a severe illness, whose nature was never clearly recorded, which left him permanently deaf. During his recovery he painted a series of small pictures on tinplate, which he himself called works of 'caprice and invention'. These pieces departed from the pleasant models he had produced for the royal palaces and mark the start of his mature phase.

Losing his hearing isolated him from conversation, but it did not stop his work. His outlook became more introspective and critical. In his prints, such as the Caprichos, and in his drawings, he denounced superstition, ignorance and the corruption of his time. In later years he settled in a country house near Madrid, known as the Quinta del Sordo, where he painted directly onto its walls the so-called Black Paintings, sombre works now seen as an early step toward modern art.

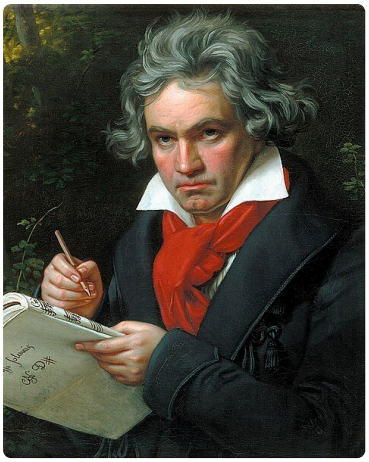
Several hypotheses have been proposed about the cause of his illness, and all of them are debated. Some researchers have suggested lead poisoning, linked to the pigments and materials painters used at the time; others have proposed infections or vascular disorders. None has been confirmed. The medicine of his day lacked the tools to identify the exact origin of a hearing loss of this kind, and the records do not describe an effective treatment.

In 1824 Goya moved to Bordeaux, accompanied by his young maid and companion Leocadia Weiss. There he suffered a stroke that left his right side paralysed, and he died in 1828. His deafness did not end his painting; it changed the way he looked at the world, and in that silence he made some of his most intense and free works.

Key dates

- **1793**: a severe illness leaves him permanently deaf.
- **1793-1794**: during his convalescence he paints his tinplate pictures, on invented subjects.
- **1819**: he settles in the Quinta del Sordo and begins the Black Paintings.
- **1824**: he moves to Bordeaux, where he spends his last years.
- **1828**: he dies in Bordeaux after a stroke.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/francisco-de-goya.html



07

Ludwig van Beethoven

1770–1827 · German composer and pianist

Illness: Progressive deafness

Ludwig van Beethoven (Bonn, 1770 – Vienna, 1827) was a German composer and pianist who, after a youth marked by family pressure, settled in Vienna, where he wrote much of his work. His music bridged the Classical and Romantic eras, and his life is closely tied to an affliction that accompanied him for nearly three decades: a progressive loss of hearing.

The first symptoms appeared around 1798, when the composer was almost thirty. He began to notice ringing in the ears and difficulty hearing clearly, especially high-pitched sounds and conversation in noisy settings. The deafness advanced gradually and, over the years, became so severe that much of his communication with performers and publishers was conducted in writing, through conversation notebooks in which his interlocutors jotted down their remarks.

In his time, physicians had no effective treatment for this kind of hearing loss. Purgatives, baths, bloodletting and assorted remedies were used, and none of them halted the process. Beethoven tried many of them in a constant search for relief that brought no lasting results.

Modern medicine has not reached a settled diagnosis. Retrospective hypotheses have been proposed, such as otosclerosis, a stiffening of the tiny bones of the middle ear that impairs the transmission of sound, or inner-ear damage linked to immune disorders. None has been conclusively confirmed, and some specialists argue that several causes may have combined. In recent years it has also been suggested that his general health, including digestive and liver problems, may have played a part; these remain debated proposals.

Deafness transformed his professional life. He stopped performing in public as a pianist, and his social dealings became more guarded and, at times, more strained. Yet rather than withdrawing from composition, he sought new ways of working. His output grew more ambitious, with symphonies, sonatas and string quartets that stretched the inherited forms. Many critics see in his final period, marked by near-total deafness, some of his most personal creations.

Around 1827 his health declined. After several months of illness that kept him bedridden, he died in Vienna on 26 March that year. His case has become a symbol of creative work surviving a limitation that would have ended the career of many musicians.

Key dates

- **1798** The first symptoms of hearing loss appear.
- **1802** He writes a letter to his brothers describing his anguish over his deafness.
- **1811** His Piano Concerto No. 5 premieres without him as soloist, owing to his growing deafness.
- **1827** He dies in Vienna after several months of illness, at the age of 56.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/ludwig-van-beethoven.html



08

Jane Austen

1775–1817 · English novelist (1775–1817)

Illness: Tuberculosis (disputed diagnosis)

Jane Austen was an English novelist of the Georgian era, author of works such as Pride and Prejudice and Emma, which portray with irony the everyday life of the rural landed gentry and the place women held in marriage.

For much of her life there were no clear signs of serious illness. The first symptoms appeared in 1816, a year after she had begun Persuasion, when she started to feel unwell without an identifiable cause. Her condition worsened over that year and the next. In early 1817 she had to abandon Sanditon, her last unfinished novel, because she could no longer work regularly.

In her time there were no laboratory tests capable of identifying the cause of a progressive decline. Physicians relied on observing symptoms and prescribed general remedies, with no effective treatment available. To receive medical attention she moved to Winchester, where she died on 18 July 1817, at the age of 41. According to the accounts that survive, her last words were ‘I want nothing but death’. In her will she left everything to her sister Cassandra.

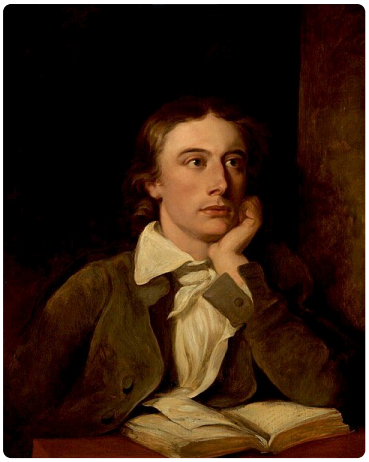
Her contemporaries never settled on the origin of her illness. The diagnosis most often cited is tuberculosis, an infection that mainly affected the lungs and was very common in nineteenth-century England. For decades, Addison’s disease has also been proposed, a disorder of the adrenal glands that causes extreme tiredness, weight loss and weakness, described by the physician Thomas Addison in 1855, almost forty years after her death. Historians of medicine still debate which hypothesis is more likely, and neither can be confirmed, since no detailed laboratory results or medical reports have survived.

Austen did not live to see the recognition that came later. Her novels were first published anonymously and enjoyed moderate success. Persuasion and Northanger Abbey appeared posthumously at the end of 1817, thanks to her brother Henry. The epitaph on her grave in Winchester Cathedral does not mention that she was a writer; a plaque added in 1872 does. Today she is one of the most widely read authors in English literature.

Key dates

- **1783** Catches typhus in Southampton and nearly dies.
- **1816** Begins to feel unwell, with the first symptoms of her illness.
- **1817** Abandons Sanditon because of her health and dies in Winchester on 18 July.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/jane-austen.html



09

John Keats

1795–1821 · English Romantic poet

Illness: Tuberculosis

John Keats (London, 1795 – Rome, 1821) was one of the leading English poets of the Romantic movement, and he died at the age of twenty-five without seeing much of his work fully recognised during his lifetime. Tuberculosis, a bacterial infection that mainly damages the lungs and was then known as consumption, marked his youth. His mother died of the disease in 1810, and a few years later he watched his brother Tom suffer from it as well; Keats nursed him until Tom's death in 1818. During a walking tour of Scotland and Ireland that same year, the poet himself began to show the first symptoms, and when he returned his health had visibly worsened.

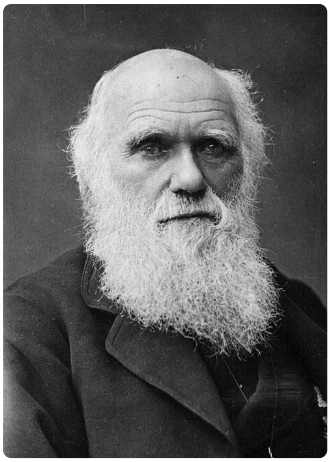
At the time there was no effective treatment for tuberculosis. Doctors recommended rest, good food, fresh air and, above all, a change of climate, and the usual advice for patients was to move somewhere warm. Keats had trained as a surgeon's apprentice and apothecary and had studied at Guy's Hospital in London, so he understood the medical language of his day at first hand. When his condition deteriorated in 1820, his doctors advised him to leave the cold London winters for Italy. He reached Rome in the company of the painter Joseph Severn and died there on 23 February 1821. Today it is generally accepted that tuberculosis caused his death. Some biographers have suggested that emotional distress also contributed to his decline, but this idea is debated and cannot be verified with certainty.

The illness shaped both his personal life and his poetry. It forced him to end his relationship with Fanny Brawne, whom he had met in London, and it coloured his final writings. During the period later called his annus mirabilis, in 1819, he composed some of his best-known odes, among them «Ode to a Nightingale» and «Ode on a Grecian Urn», in which beauty, the brevity of life and the nearness of death play a central role. His epitaph, which according to his own wish reads «Here lies One Whose Name was writ in Water», reflects that awareness. After his death, Shelley dedicated the elegy «Adonais» to him.

Key dates

- **1810** His mother, Frances, dies of tuberculosis, and the children are left in the care of their grandmother.
- **1818** His brother Tom dies of tuberculosis, while Keats begins to show symptoms during a tour of Scotland and Ireland.
- **1820** His illness worsens and his doctors advise him to travel to Italy.
- **1821** He dies in Rome on 23 February, aged twenty-five.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/john-keats.html



10

Charles Darwin

1809–1882 · English naturalist, architect of the theory of evolution by natural selection

Illness: Stammering and chronic fatigue syndrome (retrospective diagnoses)

Charles Robert Darwin (1809-1882) was an English naturalist and the author of the theory of evolution by natural selection, set out in On the Origin of Species (1859). Before devoting himself fully to biology, he studied medicine at the University of Edinburgh. He abandoned that course because the lectures bored him and surgery troubled him deeply. He attended two operations in the hospital and fled both times. Decades later he recalled that experience as coming before «the blessed days of chloroform», when anaesthetic gas had not yet become common in operating theatres.

His health is documented in less detail than his work. The reference record lists two conditions: stammering and chronic fatigue syndrome. The sources consulted do not describe the symptoms of either in detail, nor the treatments he received, so any explanation should be read as a hypothesis. Stammering is a speech disorder in which fluency is broken by repetitions or blocks. Chronic fatigue syndrome describes intense, persistent exhaustion that does not improve with rest. It is a modern term, so applying it to a nineteenth-century man is an interpretation by historians, not a diagnosis of his time.

Victorian medicine had few answers for such problems. Physicians prescribed rest, changes of air and remedies of very uneven effectiveness, and no test existed that could pinpoint a specific cause.

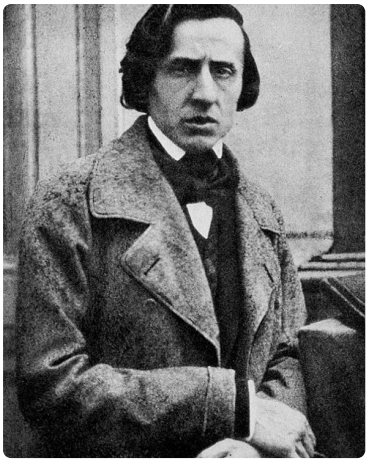
Modern medical historians have proposed retrospective diagnoses for his digestive and exhaustion symptoms. One of the most debated is Chagas disease, caused by a parasite spread by insects, which some researchers suggest he may have caught during the voyage of the Beagle. The hypothesis is unconfirmed, and other authors propose nervous or allergic explanations. None has been accepted unanimously.

His ailments shaped his daily life. He spent long periods at his home, Down House, where he organised his work into short, carefully spaced sessions. Despite this, he left an extensive and rigorous body of work that transformed biology and remains his most lasting legacy.

Key dates

- **1825** Spends the summer as an apprentice doctor with his father, then begins medical studies in Edinburgh.
- **1831** Passes his final Cambridge examination, coming tenth out of 178 candidates.
- **1832** On 24 September, makes fossil discoveries in Argentina that awaken his interest in the changeability of species.
- **1859** Publishes On the Origin of Species, setting out natural selection.
- **1882** Dies at Down House on 19 April.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/charles-darwin.html



11

Frédéric Chopin

1810–1849 · Polish pianist and composer

Illness: Tuberculosis

Frédéric Chopin (Żelazowa Wola, 1810 – Paris, 1849) was one of the great pianists and composers of the Romantic era, and he wrote almost exclusively for the piano. Born at a country estate near Warsaw, he showed early talent that led him to give his first public concerts at the age of seven and to compose his first pieces shortly afterwards.

His health was fragile from childhood. According to his biographers, he suffered from swollen glands in the neck and was often bled, a common treatment of the period that aimed to rebalance the body's fluids. His younger sister Emilia died at fourteen, probably of tuberculosis, an infectious disease caused by a bacterium that mainly attacks the lungs and was one of the leading causes of death in nineteenth-century Europe. For most of his life, Chopin's health was precarious, with bouts of fever, coughing and weakness that grew worse over the years.

When he died in Paris at the age of 39, tuberculosis was the diagnosis most accepted by his contemporaries and by historians, although medicine at the time had no effective cures. Doctors recommended rest, changes of climate and the usual remedies of the day, which rarely halted the disease. Today it is generally accepted that tuberculosis was the main cause of his death, although some researchers have suggested another lung disease, such as cystic fibrosis. This hypothesis remains debated, since the available evidence is limited.

The illness shaped his life and work in deep ways. His periods of better health coincided with some of his most productive phases, such as the stay in Mallorca with George Sand, which was unhappy on a personal level but very fruitful musically. His delicate constitution is also reflected in his playing, which was intimate and nuanced, far removed from the showy virtuosity of many of his contemporaries. Chopin thus became a symbol of the Romantic ideal, in which fragility and passion are bound up with artistic creation.

Key dates

- **1810** Born in Żelazowa Wola, into a family of French origin settled in Polish society.
- **1817** Composes his first works, two polonaises, which his father writes down because the young boy's musical notation was still limited.
- **1830** Leaves Poland shortly before the outbreak of the November Uprising and settles in Paris the following year.
- **1837** His health worsens after the break-up of his engagement to Maria Wodzińska, and bouts of coughing and fever become more frequent.
- **1849** Dies in Paris at the age of 39, with tuberculosis as the most accepted diagnosis.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/frederic-chopin.html



12

Robert Schumann

1810–1856 · German Romantic composer and pianist

Illness: Bipolar disorder

Robert Schumann (Zwickau, 1810 – Bonn, 1856) was one of the most representative composers of the Romantic period in music. Before devoting himself fully to music he had studied law, intending to become a virtuoso pianist. An injury to his right hand, whose cause is disputed, ended that concert career and led him to focus on composition, producing a wide body of work for piano, songs, symphonies and a single opera.

The first signs of his illness appeared in 1833, when the deaths of his brother Julius and his sister-in-law Rosalie during a cholera epidemic brought on a severe depressive episode. From 1834 the crises became more frequent: periods of deep melancholy and withdrawal alternated with phases of intense excitement, and over the years he developed delusions of being poisoned or threatened with metal objects, as well as hallucinations. For much of his life, however, his periods of lucidity were extraordinarily productive, and once he recovered he threw himself into composing with remarkable intensity, often to the point of exhaustion.

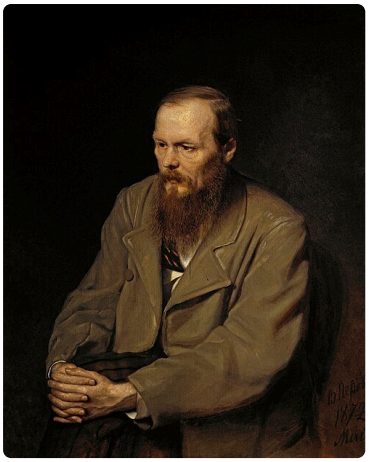
Medicine of his time had no precise psychiatric diagnoses. A range of treatments was tried, including allopathy, homeopathy and electrotherapy, without success. For a long time it was suspected that his mental decline was linked to syphilis or to the mercury used to treat it, but this idea was dismissed because his symptoms appeared in his youth, before any sign of infection could have appeared. Today the most widely accepted explanation is bipolar disorder, an illness that alternates episodes of very elevated mood with depressive episodes. Some researchers argue that mercury exposure may have worsened his condition, although this remains a debated hypothesis.

In 1854, after a suicide attempt, Schumann asked to be admitted to a psychiatric sanatorium near Bonn, where he died two years later, aged 46, without recovering. His illness did not silence his work, but it shaped his biography: his final years were dominated by instability, and critics have long debated whether his late works show a loss of inspiration. His legacy, however, remains central to the Romantic repertoire, and his music, full of characters and literary references, captured the emotional intensity of his era.

Key dates

- **1833** The deaths of his brother and sister-in-law trigger a severe depressive episode.
- **1834** Recurring crises begin, with phases of depression and excitement, and he founds the magazine Neue Zeitschrift für Musik.
- **1854** After a suicide attempt, he voluntarily enters a psychiatric sanatorium near Bonn.
- **1856** He dies at the sanatorium, aged 46, of pneumonia.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/robert-schumann.html



13

Fyodor Dostoyevsky

1821–1881 · Russian novelist and thinker

Illness: Epilepsy

Fyodor Dostoevsky (1821–1881) is among the most celebrated novelists in world literature, and his work made the troubled inner life of his characters its central subject. For most of his adult life he lived with epilepsy, a neurological condition in which bursts of abnormal electrical activity in the brain cause seizures, sometimes with convulsions and loss of consciousness.

The first symptoms probably appeared during his years as an engineering student in Saint Petersburg, around 1838, although a formal diagnosis took almost a decade. In 1847 he had a severe seizure in public in front of Saint Isaac's Cathedral and was attended by his friend Dr Ianovski. In 1857, in Barnaul, a doctor confirmed the diagnosis. In 1863 he travelled to Berlin and Paris to consult the specialists Romberg and Trousseau.

Medicine in his time had few tools. Bromides, the first anticonvulsant drugs to be widely used, were given with side effects that often outweighed their benefit, and the causes of epilepsy were poorly understood. Today, retrospective diagnoses remain a matter of debate. His descriptions of his seizures suggest a focal epilepsy, probably of temporal origin, but historians and doctors do not fully agree on the exact nature of his condition.

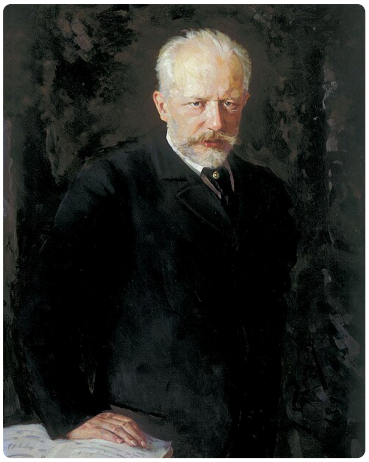
The illness left a deep mark on his writing. He gave epileptic traits to several characters, among them Myshkin in The Idiot and Kirillov in Demons, and described auras of ecstasy, a feeling of fullness that comes just before consciousness is lost. Many readers see in these experiences the source of one of his central ideas: that a single good memory can sustain a whole life. In 1928 Sigmund Freud linked the worsening of his seizures to guilt over his father's death, a reading that remains a hypothesis.

Epilepsy also had practical consequences. During his exile in Siberia, reports from military doctors helped him avoid a lifetime of compulsory military service. The illness shaped his days but did not define his work; he turned suffering into literature.

Key dates

- **1838** His first symptoms probably begin during his studies in Saint Petersburg.
- **1847** He has a seizure in public in front of Saint Isaac's Cathedral.
- **1857** A doctor in Barnaul confirms the diagnosis of epilepsy.
- **1863** He travels to Berlin and Paris to consult the specialists Romberg and Trousseau.
- **1974** Waxman and Geschwind describe a personality profile associated with this type of epilepsy.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/fiodor-dostoyevski.html



14

Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky

1840–1893 · Russian Romantic-period composer

Illness: Recurrent depression and cholera (attributed cause of death)

Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky was one of the most celebrated Russian composers of the Romantic period. He wrote the ballets Swan Lake, The Sleeping Beauty and The Nutcracker, as well as the Sixth Symphony, known as the Pathétique. Born in 1840 in Votkinsk, into a middle-class family, he died in Saint Petersburg in 1893, at the age of fifty-three.

His medical history is less documented than his music, and much of what we know comes from his letters and from accounts written by people who knew him. What is known with most confidence is that his life was marked by personal crises and periods of depression that recurred in adulthood. Among the factors that may have contributed to this distress are his early separation from his mother, when he was sent to a boarding school in Saint Petersburg; his brief and disastrous marriage to Antonina Miliukova in 1877; and his fear that his homosexuality would be exposed, a secret he kept private. Some historians regard the last as a decisive factor; others argue it has been overstated. A medical record also lists measles, though no details of that illness are known.

The death of his mother, Aleksandra, from cholera in 1854 was a blow that stayed with him for the rest of his life. His father also caught the disease but recovered. In the nineteenth century cholera was a widespread intestinal infection, and medicine of the time had no effective cure; care focused mainly on easing symptoms.

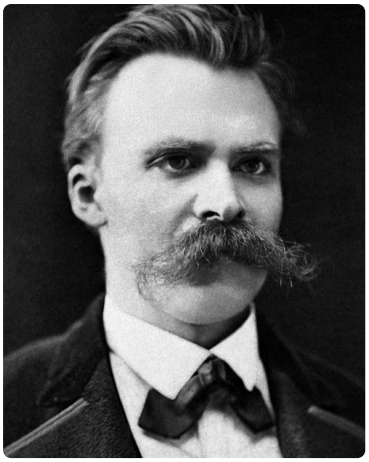
Tchaikovsky died suddenly in 1893. His death was officially attributed to cholera, although there is debate over whether that was truly the cause. Some historians argue that it may have been suicide, a hypothesis others reject for lack of conclusive evidence. Today the retrospective diagnosis remains an open question, and specialists do not agree.

His break with his patroness, Nadezhda von Meck, in 1890 was especially painful. She was facing health problems and financial difficulties, and the relationship ended abruptly. Meanwhile his fame spread across Europe, and his works were performed in concert halls around the world. The emotional intensity of his music was, for many critics, something new in Russian music, and his work remains one of the most performed in the classical repertoire.

Key dates

- **1854** His mother, Aleksandra, dies of cholera, an event that marked his youth.
- **1877** His marriage to Antonina Miliukova ends after a brief period together, amid a deep personal crisis.
- **1890** His supportive relationship with Nadezhda von Meck ends abruptly, deeply affecting him.
- **1893** He dies suddenly in Saint Petersburg; cholera is the officially attributed cause, though the debate continues.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/piotr-ilich-chaikovski.html



15

Friedrich Nietzsche

1844–1900 · German philosopher, writer and philologist

Illness: Chronic ill health and vascular dementia

Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900) was a German philosopher, writer and philologist who began as a professor of classical philology in Basel and devoted his final working years to a philosophical body of work of enormous influence. His health was fragile for most of his life, and this fragility shaped both his teaching and his writing.

The first symptoms appeared early. As a young man he suffered general weakness, vision problems that bordered on blindness, severe migraines and violent stomach pains. A riding accident in 1868, which tore muscles in his side, and the illnesses he caught in 1870 while serving briefly as a medical orderly in the Franco-Prussian War worsened this condition. He contracted diphtheria and dysentery, and in 1879 he had to give up his chair at Basel because of his declining health.

Around 1865 it is generally accepted that he contracted syphilis during a visit to a brothel in Cologne, although the details of that visit have been widely debated. Doctors of his time had no effective treatment for this infection, and the common remedies were limited and often harmful. Today the retrospective diagnoses are hypotheses: some specialists link his symptoms to late-stage syphilis, others to disturbed blood flow in the brain, and there is no consensus on the weight of each factor.

In 1889, at the age of 44, he suffered a neurological collapse and lost almost all of his mental faculties. Scholars describe paralysis and vascular dementia, meaning brain decline linked to reduced blood supply. He lived eleven more years, first under the care of his mother and later of his sister Elisabeth, who after his death took charge of his manuscripts and edited them in a way that many specialists believe distorted his thought. He died in Weimar in 1900.

The illness shaped his life and work. Leaving his chair gave him the freedom to write, but it also drove him into a life of travel, solitude and financial insecurity, moving in search of milder climates. Many readers have found in his texts a reflection on suffering and human fragility, although it is wise not to credit the illness with the origin of his ideas.

Key dates

- **1865** He visits Cologne and, it is generally accepted, contracts syphilis, though the details remain disputed.
- **1868** A riding accident tears muscles in his side and forces him to leave military service.
- **1870** He contracts diphtheria and dysentery while serving as a medical orderly in the Franco-Prussian War.
- **1879** He resigns his Basel chair after a decline in health that prevents him from working.
- **1889** He suffers a neurological collapse that leaves him without mental faculties until his death.
- **1900** He dies in Weimar on 25 August, eleven years after his collapse.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/friedrich-nietzsche.html



16

Sarah Bernhardt

1844–1923 · French stage actress who kept working after the amputation of one leg

Illness: Chronic right knee injury leading to amputation

Rosine Bernardt, known professionally as Sarah Bernhardt, was one of the leading figures of the French stage in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. She played both female and male roles, from Shakespeare's Prince Hamlet to the heroine of La Dame aux camélias, and she also worked as a sculptor and painter. Problems with her right leg shaped much of her later life.

According to the sources, the origin of her condition goes back to childhood. She fell from a window and broke her right knee. The injury healed without any obvious complications, but the joint remained fragile for the rest of her life. A fracture of this kind in a child can leave lasting effects, although the treatment she received at the time is not documented in detail.

Decades later, in 1914, the knee became painfully inflamed. The sources do not specify the exact diagnosis of that inflammation. By the medical standards of the period, when a serious infection of bone or joint did not respond to other treatments, amputation could be the only way to halt its progress. That was the decision taken in her case, and her right leg was amputated.

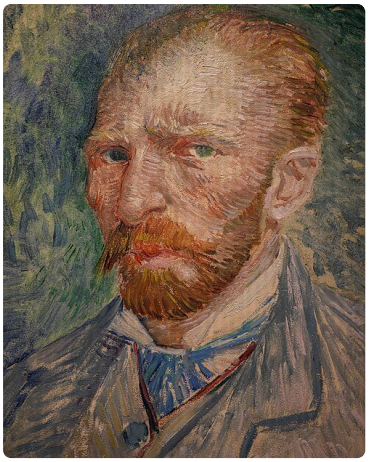
From today's perspective, some historians have put forward retrospective hypotheses about the cause, among them a chronic bone infection that may have developed from the childhood injury. These remain debated and cannot be confirmed with certainty from the surviving records, so they are best understood as reasoned speculation.

The amputation did not end her career. She continued acting, went on tours and, in her final years, worked almost exclusively at the Theatre des Nations in Paris, the only French theatre where she performed during the last twenty-four years of her life. She died in Paris on 26 March 1923, aged seventy-eight, leaving a career that combined the stage, sculpture and painting.

Key dates

- **1914** Painful inflammation of the right knee leads to the amputation of the leg.
- **1923** She dies in Paris on 26 March, aged seventy-eight.
- **Around 1850** A fall from a window breaks her right knee, an injury that leaves the joint fragile for life.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/sarah-bernhardt.html



17

Vincent van Gogh

1853–1890 · Dutch Post-Impressionist painter

Illness: Psychotic and mood disorders

Vincent van Gogh (1853-1890) was a Dutch painter and one of the key figures of Post-Impressionism. His bold colours and expressive brushwork helped lay the foundations of modern art. The son of a Protestant minister, he spent a restless youth in boarding schools and worked as an art dealer before committing to painting at the age of twenty-seven. His younger brother Theo supported him financially and emotionally for the rest of his life, and the letters the two exchanged are now a key source for understanding his work.

Signs of his distress appeared early, in a melancholy, withdrawn young man with a difficult temper. After a period of intense religious devotion and work as a missionary in a Belgian mining region, his crises became more frequent. During his stay in Arles in 1888 and 1889, he had episodes that today would be described as psychotic, with hallucinations and delusions, and in a fit of rage after a quarrel with Paul Gauguin he cut off part of his left ear. He then spent time in psychiatric hospitals, including Saint-Rémy, where he painted some of his best-known works.

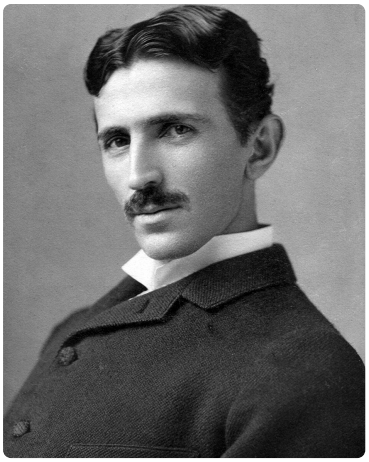
At the time, there was no precise diagnosis for conditions like his. Doctors spoke of epilepsy, of madness and of a serious nervous disorder, and treatment was limited to rest, isolation and sedatives in some cases. Modern specialists have proposed several retrospective hypotheses, including bipolar disorder, temporal lobe epilepsy, or a combination of conditions, but none has been confirmed and the debate remains open. It is also disputed whether his illness shaped his style. Some critics argue that his paintings were made with considerable control, and that he rarely worked during his crises.

In his final months at Auvers-sur-Oise, under the care of the physician Paul Gachet, his mood worsened. On 27 July 1890 he shot himself in the chest and died two days later. His work was little valued during his lifetime; recognition came after his death, through exhibitions and the publication of his letters, and he is now considered one of the great masters of painting. His medical story continues to fascinate, but it is worth remembering that the image of the tormented artist was built largely after his death.

Key dates

- **1864**: he is placed in a boarding school in Zevenbergen, where he feels abandoned.
- **1880**: he settles in Brussels and begins his formal artistic training.
- **1888**: in Arles he suffers his first severe crises, with psychotic episodes and delusions.
- **1889**: after the ear incident, he is admitted to the hospital at Saint-Rémy.
- **1890**: he moves to Auvers-sur-Oise and dies on 29 July after shooting himself in the chest.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/vincent-van-gogh.html



18

Nikola Tesla

1856–1943 · Serbian-American inventor and engineer

Illness: Synesthesia and youthful cholera

Nikola Tesla was an inventor and engineer born in Smiljan, in the Austrian Empire, in what is now Croatia. He later became a naturalized American citizen. He is best known for the polyphase alternating current system and the induction motor, but his health also forms part of his story.

Information about his conditions is scarce and partly indirect. The record that documents his case lists synesthesia, a neurological condition in which stimulation of one sense produces perceptions in another, such as associating colours with sounds. It is not a disease in the strict sense, and the sources do not describe in detail how Tesla experienced it. Some historians have suggested it may have shaped his habit of visualising entire machines in his mind before building them, but this remains a speculative and debated hypothesis.

A serious episode is documented in his youth. After graduating from the gymnasium in 1873, he returned to Smiljan and contracted cholera, an acute intestinal infection that causes severe diarrhoea and rapid loss of fluids. He spent nine months in bed and on several occasions came close to death. Medicine of the period had no specific cure and relied on supportive care, such as rest and replacing lost fluids. Today cholera is prevented through clean water and sanitation, and rehydration remains its main treatment. According to his own account, he read Mark Twain's works during his recovery.

During his early years he also suffered repeated episodes of illness, though the sources do not specify their nature. None of them stopped his studies. He continued to train in engineering and physics and, as an adult, he kept an intense working life, with his own laboratories and long days.

Tesla died on 7 January 1943 in a room at the Hotel New Yorker, where he lived alone. The medical examiner who viewed the body recorded coronary thrombosis, meaning the blockage of a heart artery by a blood clot. That diagnosis is the one recorded at the time, and there is no consensus on how his earlier conditions may have affected his health.

His medical history is known mainly through his public career. He never paid much attention to his finances and spent his last years in hotels, often leaving bills unpaid, yet his technical legacy was recognised over time. In 1960 the international unit of magnetic flux density was named the tesla in his honour.

Key dates

- **1856** Born in Smiljan, in the Austrian Empire, now part of Croatia.
- **1873** After graduating, he contracts cholera and remains bedridden for nine months, close to death on several occasions.
- **1943** Dies in New York; the medical examiner attributes the death to coronary thrombosis.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/nikola-tesla.html



19

Anton Chekhov

1860–1904 · Russian writer and physician

Illness: Tuberculosis

Anton Pavlovich Chekhov (Taganrog, 1860 – Badenweiler, 1904) was a Russian short story writer, playwright and physician, and one of the most admired authors of the short story in literary history. He combined his literary career with medicine, a profession he considered his principal one. In a letter he described medicine as his lawful wife and literature as his mistress.

Tuberculosis, an infectious disease that mainly affects the lungs and had no effective cure in his day, appeared in Chekhov around 1884 and 1885, when he began coughing up blood. The attacks worsened in 1886, yet he did not admit the seriousness of his condition to his family or friends. In 1887 clearer symptoms led him to travel to Ukraine, and in the years that followed his health declined unevenly, with periods of improvement and relapse.

At the time, tuberculosis was treated with rest, good nutrition, fresh air and long stays in mild climates or rest centres, since no specific drugs existed. Chekhov followed this path: he travelled to the Black Sea coast at Yalta and later to western Europe in search of a gentler climate. His journey to Sakhalin Island in 1890 was an exhausting trip that, according to some accounts, further weakened his body.

Today tuberculosis is generally regarded as the cause of his death, although the details of his clinical course are debated by historians and physicians, who discuss how far travel and living conditions contributed to his decline. His final years were marked by illness and the search for kinder climates. He died in Badenweiler, Germany, in 1904, at the age of forty-four.

The illness also left its mark on his work. His medical practice gave him direct knowledge of the poverty and hardship of Russian peasants, which appears in stories such as Peasants. His clinical eye, attentive to detail and little given to moral judgement, shaped his restrained style and his treatment of characters. Writing with the urgency of someone who knows time is short, he left plays such as The Seagull, Uncle Vanya, Three Sisters and The Cherry Orchard, which rank among the classics of modern theatre.

Key dates

- **1884**: He qualifies as a physician and practises medicine while continuing to write.
- **1885**: The first episodes of coughing with blood appear.
- **1887**: Symptoms become more evident and he travels to Ukraine in search of rest.
- **1890**: He undertakes the long journey to Sakhalin Island while his health is failing.
- **1897**: He suffers a serious health crisis and moves to a milder climate.
- **1904**: He dies in Badenweiler, Germany, from tuberculosis.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/anton-chejov.html



20

Helen Keller

1880–1968 · deafblind American writer, speaker and political activist

Illness: Deafblindness after childhood infection

Helen Adams Keller (1880–1968) was an American writer, lecturer and political activist who lost her sight and hearing in early childhood and became the first deafblind person to earn a university degree in the United States.

At nineteen months old she fell seriously ill. Doctors of the time described an "acute congestion of the stomach and the brain", a vague label that does not identify the cause. Retrospective hypotheses include meningitis, scarlet fever or rubella, but none can be confirmed with certainty. The fever eventually subsided and she survived, but the illness left her permanently blind and deaf. For years she communicated through home signs, and her frustration at being unable to understand those around her often led to violent outbursts of temper.

At around seven, her parents sought help. A Baltimore physician referred them to Alexander Graham Bell, who advised them to contact the Perkins Institute for the Blind in Boston. There the school assigned Anne Sullivan, a young teacher who had been a pupil there and who was herself visually impaired, as Helen's instructor. Sullivan stayed by her side for almost fifty years. Her approach treated the girl like any other pupil, spelling words into her palm and linking them to objects, and later teaching braille and the Tadoma method, which allows a person to read speech through touch. Helen learned braille quickly, and her temperament changed markedly.

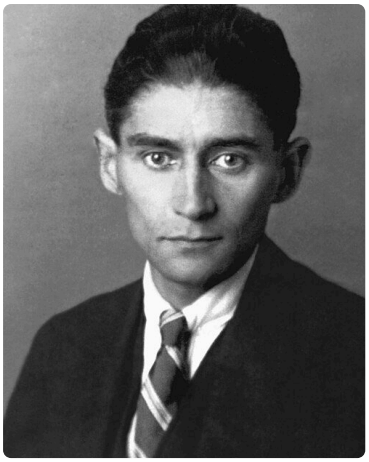
After secondary school she entered Radcliffe College, graduating in 1904. Her autobiography, The Story of My Life (1903), made her education and life widely known, and her later books included Light in My Darkness (1927). She campaigned for people with disabilities, women's suffrage and labour rights, and joined the Socialist Party in 1909 according to most sources. Her lecturing also helped raise funds for the American Foundation for the Blind.

Deafblindness shaped both her private life and her public role. Her story shows how a woman could build a public voice through communication methods very different from those usually taught. She died in 1968, and her legacy remains closely linked to the education of deafblind people.

Key dates

- **1880**: Born in Tuscumbia, Alabama, with normal sight and hearing.
- **1882**: An illness of uncertain cause leaves her permanently blind and deaf.
- **1887**: Anne Sullivan arrives and begins teaching her through finger spelling.
- **1888**: Enters the Perkins Institute for the Blind in Boston.
- **1904**: Graduates from Radcliffe College, the first deafblind person in the United States to earn a bachelor's degree.
- **1936**: Anne Sullivan dies, after decades as her teacher and companion.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/helen-a-keller.html



21

Franz Kafka

1883–1924 · Bohemian writer in German

Illness: Pulmonary tuberculosis

Franz Kafka (Prague, 1883 – Kierling, 1924) was a German-language writer born in Prague, then the capital of the Kingdom of Bohemia within the Austro-Hungarian Empire, and one of the most influential authors of twentieth-century literature. His works blend realism with the fantastic, and typically follow isolated characters who face absurd situations and incomprehensible bureaucratic powers. This is why the word "Kafkaesque" has entered everyday language.

The illness that ended his life was tuberculosis, a bacterial infection that mainly affects the lungs and, at the time, had no cure. According to his biographers, Kafka had a fragile constitution from his youth: by about 1905 he already needed to stay in sanatoriums because of his physical weakness. The tuberculosis diagnosis came in 1917, when the disease became clearly visible through coughing, fatigue and loss of strength. The treatments available were mainly rest, diet and stays in sanatoriums, since no effective drug existed. For this reason he spent much of his last years in rest centres, away from his work and his writing.

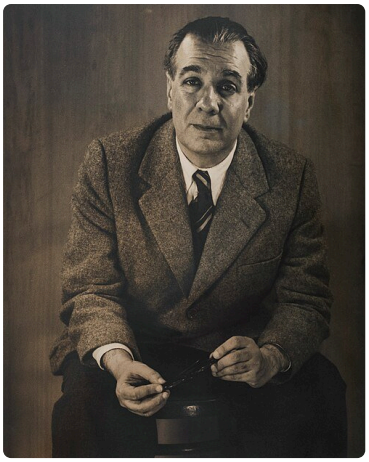
Modern medicine accepts the same diagnosis, but historians debate how far the illness shaped Kafka's character and work. Some argue that his physical frailty deepened his sense of isolation and guilt, while others believe his temperament and family conflicts explain those themes better. What is documented is that the illness forced him to leave his insurance job: he retired early in 1922, which gave him more time to write, though his health was already badly damaged.

Tuberculosis also marked his final personal years. During his periods of convalescence he received support from his family, especially from his sister Ottilie, his favourite, who later died in the Holocaust. Kafka died in 1924 at the age of forty, still relatively unknown. His friend Max Brod ignored his request to destroy the unpublished manuscripts and published them, and his work went on to achieve the fame the author never knew.

Key dates

- **1917** He is diagnosed with tuberculosis, which forces frequent periods of convalescence.
- **1918** The insurance company grants him a pension because of his illness, and he spends most of the rest of his life in sanatoriums.
- **1922** He retires early because of tuberculosis.
- **1924** He dies in Kierling, Austria, at the age of forty.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/franz-kafka.html



22

Jorge Luis Borges

1899–1986 · Argentine writer, poet and translator

Illness: Progressive blindness

Jorge Luis Borges was an Argentine short-story writer, poet, essayist and translator, author of the stories collected in Ficciones and El Aleph, and one of the central figures of twentieth-century literature in Spanish.

Blindness shaped much of his life. His father, Jorge Guillermo Borges, lost his sight gradually because of a hereditary condition that forced him to retire from teaching in 1914. The same process began to affect Borges himself in his thirties, and by the age of 55 he was almost completely blind.

In that period, ophthalmology had limited means to treat diseases that damage the retina or the optic nerve, the structures that carry the image to the brain. His father travelled to Europe for a specialised eye treatment, although the sources consulted do not make clear what results he obtained. For Borges, no specific diagnosis from his own time is recorded. Today, the exact cause of his loss of sight is not documented with certainty. Some specialists have suggested a hereditary origin, in line with his father's case, but this remains a hypothesis that the available evidence cannot confirm.

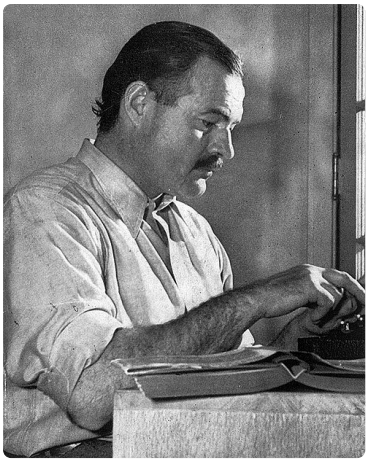
Blindness also left a clear mark on his writing. Some scholars argue that his loss of sight led him to favour poetry and short stories over novels, and to develop elaborate literary symbols such as labyrinths, mirrors and libraries, which were built through imagination rather than direct observation. This is a plausible interpretation rather than a certainty, and his work allows other readings.

His situation also affected his daily work. Before achieving fame he had worked as a librarian, teacher and lecturer, and in 1955 he was appointed director of the National Public Library of Argentina, a post he took up with his sight already greatly reduced. In 1961 he received the first International Formentor Prize, shared with Samuel Beckett, which brought him international recognition. Borges continued writing, translating and lecturing until his death in Geneva in 1986.

Key dates

- **1914** Borges's father retires from teaching because of progressive blindness, and the family travels to Europe in search of eye treatment.
- **1938** After a serious head injury on Christmas Eve, Borges nearly dies from sepsis, a widespread infection.
- **1955** He is appointed director of the National Public Library of Argentina, with his sight already greatly diminished.
- **1961** He receives the first International Formentor Prize, shared with Samuel Beckett, which brings him international fame.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/jorge-luis-borges.html



23

Ernest Hemingway

1899–1961 · American novelist and journalist

Illness: Alcoholism and hereditary hemochromatosis

Ernest Hemingway was an American novelist, short-story writer and journalist, best known for The Sun Also Rises, A Farewell to Arms and The Old Man and the Sea, and winner of the 1954 Nobel Prize in Literature. His life was marked by war wounds, accidents and a long, heavy relationship with alcohol, problems that worsened in his final years.

In July 1918, near Fossalta di Piave on the Italian Front, a mortar shell seriously wounded him in both legs while he was handing out chocolate and cigarettes to the soldiers. He underwent an emergency operation and spent five days in a field hospital before being moved to Milan, where he spent about six months recovering. Surgery at the time could save a limb, but convalescence was slow and painful, and antibiotics, which became widespread only after the Second World War, did not yet exist. These injuries stayed with him and shaped how he later wrote about war.

Alcohol was a constant presence in much of his adult life, in Paris, during his travels and during his years in Cuba. Sources document his habitual drinking, but no specific treatment for it. In his era, alcoholism was understood mainly as a moral failing or a flaw of character, and the therapies available were scarce and of limited effect. Today medicine regards it as a dependence that damages the liver, the heart and mood.

In 1954, during a safari trip in Africa, he survived two plane crashes in quick succession. The injuries left him with pain and ongoing health problems for the rest of his life, and his physical and emotional condition gradually declined. Symptoms of depression appeared in his last years. Some physicians and historians have suggested that he may have had hereditary hemochromatosis, a condition in which the body absorbs more iron than it needs and stores it in organs such as the liver, heart and pancreas, causing fatigue, joint pain and mood changes. This is a retrospective and disputed diagnosis: there is no direct evidence, and alcohol alone could have caused similar liver damage.

His health limited his capacity to work in the final years, although his books remained widely read and debated. He died by suicide at his home in Ketchum, Idaho, on July 2, 1961, at the age of 61. His medical history remains a subject of discussion among historians of medicine and his biographers.

Key dates

- **1918**: seriously wounded by shrapnel in both legs on the Italian Front.
- **1918**: spends six months recovering at the Red Cross hospital in Milan.
- **1954**: survives two plane crashes in succession during a trip to Africa.
- **1961**: dies by suicide at his home in Ketchum, Idaho, on July 2.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/ernest-hemingway.html



24

George Orwell

1903–1950 · English novelist and journalist

Illness: Tuberculosis

Eric Arthur Blair, known by the pen name George Orwell, was an English novelist, essayist and journalist born in India in 1903 and who died in London in 1950. Author of Animal Farm and Nineteen Eighty-Four, his work draws on his years as a colonial policeman in Burma, his time living in poverty in London and Paris, and his service in the Spanish Civil War.

From the early 1930s his health was often unstable, and illness forced him to leave his work as a schoolteacher. Around 1937 he returned from Spain with tuberculosis, a bacterial infection that mainly affects the lungs. At the time it was treated with long rest, good food and stays in mountain or dry-climate sanatoriums. He was admitted to a sanatorium in England and then spent time in Morocco, where the climate was thought to help recovery. Medicine of that era had no effective antibiotics, so treatment was supportive and did not cure the disease.

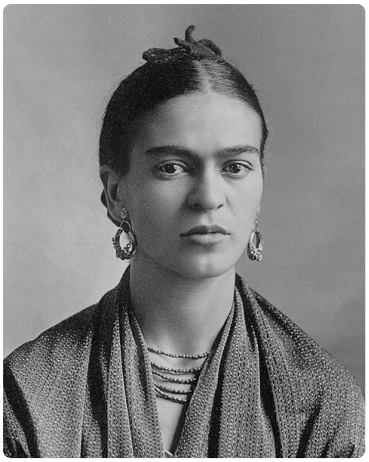
Tuberculosis worsened again during the Second World War and in the years that followed. Orwell spent his last three years moving between hospitals while finishing Nineteen Eighty-Four. Today the illness he suffered is well documented and can be treated with antibiotics, which did not exist in his time. Historians broadly agree that the lack of effective treatment shaped his final years, although it is debated how much physical exhaustion and intense work contributed to his decline.

The illness shaped both his life and his writing. It pushed him toward quiet places, forced interruptions in his activities and made every productive year precious. His last major work, written with his health gravely weakened, became one of the best-known critiques of twentieth-century totalitarianism. He died at forty-six and was buried at Sutton Courtenay in Oxfordshire, following the Anglican rite he had requested.

Key dates

- **1928** He resigns from the Indian Imperial Police in Burma to devote himself to writing.
- **1929** He falls seriously ill in Paris and is treated at the Hôpital Cochin, a free hospital where medical students were trained.
- **1937** He returns from the Spanish Civil War with tuberculosis and spends time in an English sanatorium.
- **1945** He publishes Animal Farm while his health is already weakened.
- **1950** He dies in London at the age of forty-six from tuberculosis.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/george-orwell.html



25

Frida Kahlo

1907–1954 · Mexican painter and activist

Illness: Polio and chronic pain after an accident

Magdalena Carmen Frida Kahlo y Calderón was born in Coyoacán in 1907 and died in the same district in 1954. The daughter of a German-born photographer and a mestiza mother, she spent most of her life at La Casa Azul, her family home, which is now the museum that bears her name. Polio, a viral infection that damages the motor nerves and can leave lasting paralysis, marked her health from childhood. According to the sources, she contracted it in 1913, and the aftereffects left her right leg thinner and weaker.

Her path changed in 1925, when, at the age of eighteen, the bus she was travelling on after school was struck by a tram. She suffered multiple fractures to her spine, pelvis, ribs, collarbone and right leg. Medicine of the time relied on long periods of bed rest, plaster and other corsets, and stretching devices meant to realign the bones. Over her lifetime she underwent at least 32 surgical operations. During her recovery, confined to bed, she began to paint with an adapted easel and a mirror placed above the bed, and so she started to portray herself.

Today medicine considers that her chronic pain had several origins, and her childhood diagnosis is debated. Some researchers argue that the condition of her legs may have had another cause, such as a malformation of the spine. This remains a disputed hypothesis without definitive confirmation, and the full extent of her internal injuries is not known with certainty.

Her health also shaped her private life. In 1930 she lost a pregnancy, and doctors warned her that she would probably never be able to have children. Her marriage to the painter Diego Rivera, which had begun in 1929, was turbulent. They divorced in 1939 and remarried the following year. In her work, pain and the body became central themes: spines, corsets and wounds appear in paintings that blend realism and fantasy and reflect her personal experience without concessions.

Her recognition grew after her death, especially from the late 1970s onward. She is now regarded as an icon of Mexican culture and a reference point for feminist movements. Her first solo exhibition in Mexico took place in 1953, shortly before she died.

Key dates

- **1913** She contracts polio, which leaves lasting effects on her right leg.
- **1925** A bus accident causes multiple fractures and lifelong chronic pain.
- **1930** She loses a pregnancy and is told she will probably be unable to have children.
- **1939** Her marriage to Diego Rivera ends in divorce.
- **1953** She holds her first solo exhibition in Mexico, shortly before her death.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/frida-kahlo.html



26

Édith Piaf

1915–1963 · French singer and songwriter

Illness: Childhood keratitis, arthritis and morphine dependence

Édith Piaf (Paris, 1915 – Plascassier, 1963) was one of the most celebrated voices of French song and the author of works such as “La Vie en rose” and “Non, je ne regrette rien”. Her career was marked by several health problems that, over the years, shaped her performances and her personal life.

The first episodes date from childhood. According to one of her biographers, between the ages of three and seven she was almost blind because of keratitis, an inflammation of the cornea, the transparent layer covering the front of the eye. Piaf herself attributed her recovery to a miraculous healing after a pilgrimage in honour of Saint Thérèse of Lisieux. This is a personal account rather than a documented diagnosis, so historians treat it with caution.

In 1951 she was injured in a car accident that broke an arm and two ribs. Her doctor prescribed morphine to treat what was described as arthritis, a chronic inflammatory disease of the joints. Morphine, a very powerful painkiller that medicine of the period used freely, led to a dependence that added to her problems with alcohol. Today some specialists debate whether her pain really reflected rheumatoid arthritis, an autoimmune condition, or another cause, since no clinical records survive that would allow it to be confirmed.

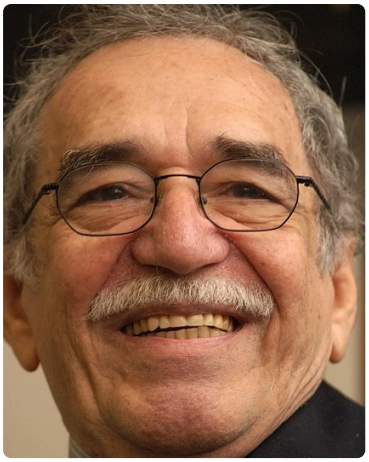
Piaf tried to detox in 1953 and again in 1956, but later car accidents, such as the one in 1958, worsened her physical condition. In 1959 she collapsed on stage during a tour in New York and underwent numerous operations. Even so, in 1961 she gave a series of concerts at the Olympia in Paris that saved the theatre from ruin, singing while sustained by high doses of morphine.

Her illness also ended her life. She died in Plascassier, at the age of 47, from liver cancer. Her story shows how pain, the treatments of the time and dependence intertwined with a body of work that, to a large extent, dealt with love, loss and sorrow.

Key dates

- **1951** Car accident with fractures to an arm and ribs; morphine is soon prescribed to treat arthritis.
- **1953** She begins a detox programme to withdraw from the medications that were harming her health.
- **1958** A serious car accident worsens her physical condition and her dependence on morphine.
- **1959** She collapses on stage during a tour in New York and undergoes several operations.
- **1961** At the Olympia in Paris she gives the concerts that save the venue, singing under high doses of morphine.
- **1963** She dies in Plascassier, aged 47, from liver cancer.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/edith-piaf.html



27

Gabriel García Márquez

1927–2014 · Colombian writer, journalist and screenwriter

Illness: Alzheimer's disease

Gabriel García Márquez was a Colombian writer, journalist and screenwriter, the author of One Hundred Years of Solitude and winner of the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1982. His illness, recorded as Alzheimer's disease, shaped the final stage of his life. The exact course of his condition is not well documented, since his family kept much of it private, so what can be said rests mainly on what relatives later shared and on the public attention given to his final years.

Alzheimer's disease is a neurodegenerative dementia, meaning that nerve cells in the brain are lost gradually. Over time it causes problems with recent memory, difficulty finding orientation and words, and changes in behaviour that worsen slowly. It affects each person differently, and in García Márquez's case the details of each phase have not been widely published.

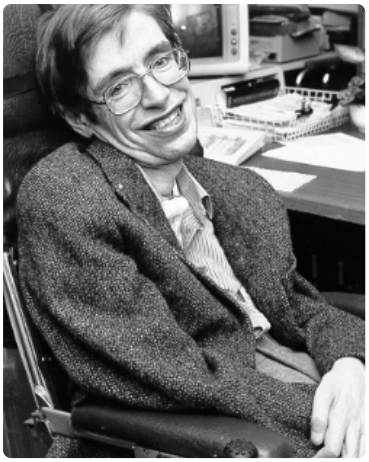
Until well into the twentieth century there were no tests to confirm the diagnosis during life. Doctors relied on the patient's history, neurological examination and observation of behaviour, and memory loss was often put down to ordinary ageing. Today the diagnosis combines cognitive tests, brain imaging and, in some cases, biological markers. There is still no treatment that stops the disease; the available drugs can only modify some symptoms to a limited extent.

The influence of the illness on his work is hard to separate from his biography. Much of his writing was done before the first symptoms appeared, and his output remains among the most influential in the Spanish language. Themes such as memory, the passage of time and solitude run through his novels, which has led many readers to connect his writing with his own life. That reading belongs more to critical interpretation than to documented fact, and it is worth keeping the two apart.

Key dates

- **1927** Born in Aracataca, Colombia, on 6 March.
- **2012** Around this period the cognitive decline that, as was later reported, marked his final years began to show.
- **2014** Died in Mexico City on 17 April, aged 87.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/gabriel-garcia-marquez.html



28

Stephen Hawking

1942–2018 · British theoretical physicist and cosmologist

Illness: Amyotrophic lateral sclerosis (ALS)

Stephen Hawking was a British theoretical physicist, cosmologist and popular science writer, best known for his work on spacetime singularities with Roger Penrose and for predicting that black holes emit radiation.

The first symptoms appeared shortly after he arrived at Cambridge to begin his doctorate. Amyotrophic lateral sclerosis (ALS) is a neurodegenerative disease that affects motor neurones, the nerve cells that carry signals from the brain to the muscles. As these cells deteriorate, the muscles weaken and waste away. Hawking was diagnosed in 1963, at the age of twenty-one, and at that time he was given a prognosis of only about two years to live. He later described this period as a time of depression, but the disease progressed far more slowly than predicted, and he was able to return to his work with the support of his supervisor, Dennis Sciama.

In the medicine of his day there was no treatment able to halt ALS, and care focused on helping with mobility and communication. Over the years he lost the use of his arms and legs, and his speech became almost unintelligible. In 1985 he underwent a tracheotomy, an opening made in the windpipe to assist breathing, which left him without a voice. From then on he communicated through a speech-generating device, first with a handheld switch and later by using a single cheek muscle.

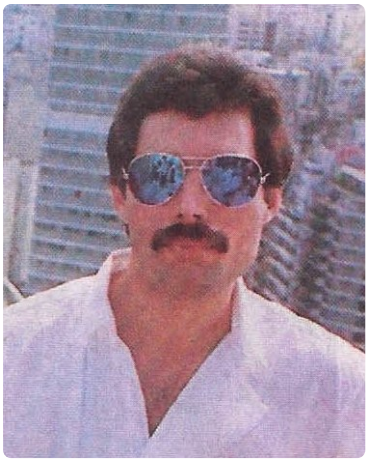
Today medicine still has no cure for ALS, and in most cases its cause is not known with certainty. After diagnosis, average survival is around fourteen months, so Hawking's survival of more than fifty years was exceptional and puzzled neurologists. The reasons for such a slow course have not been established, and any specific explanation remains a hypothesis.

The illness did not remove him from science. His work from the mid-1970s on black hole radiation, now known as Hawking radiation, came to be accepted as a major advance in theoretical physics. As a writer, A Brief History of Time, published in 1988, spent 237 weeks on the Sunday Times best-seller list. He held the Lucasian Chair of Mathematics at Cambridge from 1979 to 2009. His public example showed how a severe disability could coexist with an intense scientific career.

Key dates

- **1962** Shortly after arriving at Cambridge, the first symptoms appear.
- **1963** He is diagnosed with ALS at the age of twenty-one, with a very gloomy initial prognosis.
- **1985** A tracheotomy leaves him without a voice, and he begins communicating with a speech device.
- **2018** He dies at the age of seventy-six, after more than fifty years living with the disease.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/stephen-hawking.html



29

Freddie Mercury

1946–1991 · British singer and songwriter born in Zanzibar, lead vocalist of Queen

Illness: HIV and AIDS

Freddie Mercury, born Farrokh Bulsara, was a British singer and songwriter of Tanzanian origin and the lead vocalist of the rock band Queen, one of the most recognised voices in the history of rock. Born in Zanzibar in 1946 into a Parsi family, he moved with his relatives to England in 1964, fleeing the revolution that shook the island. His wide vocal range and commanding stage presence made him a central figure in popular music during the 1970s and 1980s.

When his health began to decline, his condition was a private matter. In April 1987 he was diagnosed with HIV, the virus that weakens the immune system, the body's defences against infection. When the immune system is severely damaged, AIDS develops, a set of infections and illnesses the body can no longer contain. At that time there were no treatments able to eliminate the virus, and those available were limited and carried significant side effects. Mercury kept much of his situation secret and went on working with Queen, recording and performing for as long as his strength allowed.

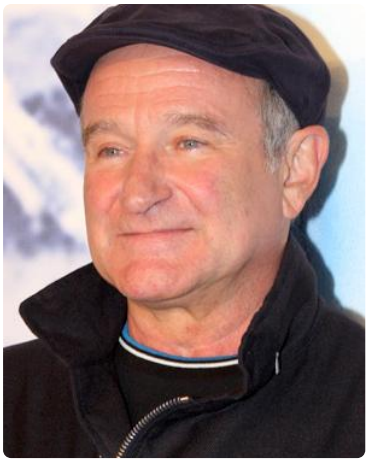
Today medicine regards HIV as a chronic infection that can be controlled with antiretroviral therapy, a treatment that reduces the virus to undetectable levels and allows a life expectancy close to that of the general population. That possibility did not exist when Mercury received his diagnosis. Doctors and historians agree that the diagnosis is well documented, but the available sources do not allow a precise reconstruction of when the infection occurred or of the detailed clinical course of his final months, so any hypothesis on these points should be treated with caution.

His illness did not stop his creative work. On 23 November 1991 he publicly announced his diagnosis, and the following day he died, at the age of 45, from complications of the disease. His voice survived on Queen's final album, Made in Heaven (1995), on which he was featured posthumously. A year later, a concert in his honour was held at Wembley Stadium to raise awareness of AIDS, turning his memory into a public cause and helping to bring the epidemic into view.

Key dates

- **1964** He flees with his family from the Zanzibar Revolution and settles in Middlesex, England.
- **1987** In April he is diagnosed with HIV, a diagnosis he largely keeps private.
- **1991** He publicly announces his diagnosis and dies on 24 November, aged 45.
- **1992** A concert in his honour is held at Wembley Stadium to raise awareness of AIDS.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/freddie-mercury.html



30

Robin Williams

1951–2014 · American actor and comedian

Illness: Dementia with Lewy bodies, depression and alcoholism

Robin McLaurin Williams (Chicago, 1951 - Paradise Cay, California, 2014) was an American comedian and actor, known for his improvisational skills and for playing both comic and dramatic roles. His awards include an Academy Award, several Golden Globes and Emmys, but his life was also marked by addiction, depression and, in his final years, a neurodegenerative illness.

Early in his career, Williams acknowledged that he began using drugs and alcohol, partly as a response to the stress of performing stand-up. He said he never performed under the influence, although on occasion he went on stage still carrying the hangover of the previous day. During the period when he used cocaine, he described feeling paranoid each time he walked onto the stage. Alcohol dependence was the addiction that weighed most on his life, and he spent years trying to control it. His medical history also includes dyslexia, a learning difference that affects reading and writing and is usually identified in childhood.

In his last years, Williams suffered from severe depression. His widow stated that he had been diagnosed with Parkinson's disease and had experienced depression, anxiety and growing paranoia. The autopsy found diffuse Lewy body disease, a form of dementia caused by abnormal protein deposits in the brain that disrupt memory, movement and mood. The specialists who reviewed the case said the symptoms were consistent with dementia with Lewy bodies. Some neurologists argue that Parkinson's and this form of dementia are closely related, so the distinction between them remains a matter of debate.

Today, any retrospective diagnosis of Williams can only be treated as a hypothesis, based on the autopsy and on the accounts of those who knew him. The treatments available in his time could not halt diseases of this kind, and his depression and addictions were approached with the limited tools psychiatry then had.

The struggle had a considerable impact on his public life and his work. Williams was admired for his generosity and humour, and he died by suicide in August 2014, which prompted a wave of tributes. His story is a reminder that mental health and addiction affect even those who seem brightest in public.

Key dates

- **1976** He begins performing stand-up comedy in San Francisco, where his career starts.
- **1978** He rises to fame with the sitcom Mork & Mindy, playing an alien.
- **1987** He receives his first Academy Award nomination for Good Morning, Vietnam.
- **1997** He wins the Academy Award for Best Supporting Actor for Good Will Hunting.
- **2014** He dies by suicide; the autopsy reveals diffuse Lewy body disease.

Full entry: medicapedia.org/en/ec/robin-williams.html

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